

The Flipside of the Sponsorship Coin

Do You Still Buy the Beer

When the Brewer Underwrites a Rival Team?

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This study investigated whether sponsorships can have negative brand effects in some subgroups in the target market. The study focused on European football (soccer), and results showed that fans of the Stockholm team AIK transferred their dislike of the rival team Hammarby to its sponsor, the beer brand Falcon. Mean scores on brand variables were considerably lower for AIK fans than for a control group who were fans of neither AIK nor Hammarby. Researchers and managers are recommended to consider possible negative effects of sponsorships in subgroups and to evaluate the target audience's attitude toward the sponsored object.

INTRODUCTION

The brand effects of sponsorships have received extensive coverage in advertising/marketing research (see overviews in Olson, 2010; Walliser, 2003). To date, this research has been based on the assumption that the sponsorship has positive effects on the brand, and studies have sought to establish whether brand associations become more positive as a result of the sponsorship.

Such research on sponsorships, however, seems to have overlooked that sponsorships may have negative effects on the brand. Although negative brand effects of sponsorships may not happen frequently, there are a number of situations in which parts of the brand's target audience may hold negative associations to the sponsored object, which may rub off on the brand. Such situations could arise in sports sponsorships—particularly in team sports where the fans of one team often dislike its rival teams. For the sponsor of one team, the negative associations held by fans of a rival team may transfer to the brand, resulting in a possible negative brand effect of sponsoring.

The present study investigated whether sponsorships could have negative brand effects within the context of European football (soccer). In European football, fierce rivalry between teams is common; fans of one team often have negative associations to its main rival.

European football is of interest not only because of the rivalries between teams but because football clubs receive large sums of sponsorship money. For example, according to one study, seven out of the ten largest sports sponsorship deals in Britain in 2001 were football sponsorships (Chadwick and Thwaites, 2005).

The context of the present study is Stockholm, Sweden, in which two local football teams—each sponsored by different beer brands—offered an opportunity for an in-market quasi-experiment to test whether sponsorships can have negative brand effects.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND AND HYPOTHESES

Sponsorships generally are assumed to have a positive effect on the sponsoring brand through a process of image transfer (see overview in Olson, 2010). The image of the sponsored object (e.g., a football club) is transferred to the sponsoring brand in the same way as image is transferred from celebrity spokespeople to brands, through a process in which associations in memory regarding the sponsored object are transferred to the sponsoring brand (Gwinner and Eaton, 1999).

In different studies, the image associations have been operationalized as, for example, brand personality (Gwinner and Eaton, 1999); brand attitude and purchase intention (Prendergast,

Poon, and West, 2010); and corporate reputation (Schwaiger, Sarstedt, and Taylor, 2010). Irrespective of the operationalization, results in empirical studies generally have demonstrated a positive image transfer effect (Olson, 2010; Walliser, 2003).

Recent research has shown that the evaluative conditioning that image transfer represents could be either direct or indirect (Sweldens, van Osselaer, and Janiszewski, 2010).

- In **direct transfer**, once the affective response has been transferred from the object to the brand, the response is generated by the brand without the object's being activated in memory.
- In **indirect transfer**, the affective response to the brand depends on the activation of the sponsored object in memory—that is, the brand will not generate the affective response independently of the sponsored object.

Direct transfer, as opposed to indirect transfer, is not sensitive to revaluation of the object (e.g., a celebrity falling from grace), as it does not depend on retrieving an association between the object and the brand from memory. One recent study showed that indirect transfer is most likely to be the result of repeated pairings of object and brand that are either sequential or simultaneous, whereas direct transfer is most likely to result from simultaneous pairings with different objects (Sweldens et al., 2010).

As sponsorships—particularly football sponsorships—entail repeated pairings of the object and the brand (and these are both sequential and simultaneous), sponsorships should result in indirect transfer. In such cases, the positive brand response is dependent on the association between the object and the brand being activated in memory.

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Several studies have shown that the perceived functional or image fit between the sponsored object and the sponsoring brand is an important moderator of image-transfer effects:

- Functional fit usually refers to a situation where the sponsor's product could be used by (or in connection with) the sponsored object.
- Image fit refers to a situation in which there is an overlap on one or many aspects of the images of the object and the sponsor (Gwinner and Eaton, 1999).

For example, one study found that image transfer was stronger for image-based fit (Gwinner and Eaton, 1999), and another demonstrated that image transfer for “thinking” products was stronger in a situation with functional fit rather than image fit and that the opposite was true for “feeling” products (Prendergast et al., 2010).

It has been argued—and, to some extent, empirically supported—that sponsorships create a goodwill effect similar to that created by philanthropy (Olson, 2010). To varying extents, sponsors are seen as donating money to the sponsored object via their sponsorships, and this act creates goodwill for the brand among those who appreciate the sponsored object. This goodwill, in turn, has positive effects on the attitude toward the sponsoring brand.

A tenet of sponsorship research is that sponsorships have positive effects on the

sponsoring brand. The possibility of negative brand effects rarely is mentioned; the “worst case” considered is no brand effects. There is no obvious reason, however, why negative associations to a sponsored object would not transfer to the sponsor in the same way as positive associations.

For example, although some of these results have been difficult to replicate and the overall picture is mixed, studies on evaluative conditioning with music have found evidence of negative image transfer (see overview in Schemer, Matthes, Wirth, and Textor, 2008). As a rule, objects with negative associations will not be chosen by sponsors, and self-selection should eliminate many cases in which sub-segments of the target market dislikes the sponsored object (e.g., people who dislike rock music are not likely to turn up at a Rolling Stones concert).

There are instances, however, in which an object has positive associations for some people and negative associations for other people. Such a situation typically arises in team-sport rivalries. In the European football (soccer) leagues, it is common to find pairs or small groups of teams wherein the rivalry between teams is particularly fierce, both on and off the football field.

For example, in the Spanish La Liga, there is the rivalry between FC Barcelona and Real Madrid; in the English Premier League, examples include West Ham United and Millwall, and Manchester United and Manchester City; in the Italian Serie A, well-known rivalries exist

between Lazio and Roma and between Inter Milan and AC Milan.

For football fans, being a supporter of one team often goes hand in hand with a dislike for the main rival team. This dislike, in most cases, takes on mild forms. Unfortunately, however, in some cases it can take on extreme forms in which football fans resort to hooliganism. In fact fans of rival teams have in a few cases killed one another.

In a sponsoring context, the question is to what extent the dislike felt for a rival team is transferred to its sponsors. As negative image transfer seems as likely as positive image transfer, the hypothesis that forms the basis of the present study is that there will be transfer of negative associations—or a general dislike—from a rival football team to its sponsors.

Accordingly, the present research investigated whether fans of one of the football teams in Stockholm, Sweden, transferred their dislike of their local rival team to the beer brand that was one of its main sponsors for many years.

RESEARCH DESIGN

Overview

The present study is based on a quasi-experiment with a “posttest-only design with nonequivalent groups” (Shadish, Cook, and Campbell, 2002, pp. 115–117). A group of fans of the Stockholm-based football team AIK were compared with a matched control group made up of people who were fans neither of AIK nor their local rival Hammarby. The experiment group and the control group responded to a Web-based survey instrument measuring their perceptions of the beer brands Åbro, which sponsors AIK, and Falcon, which (until recently) sponsored Hammarby. The data were analyzed to find out whether the brand perceptions of the experiment group differed significantly from those of the control group.

The Football Teams and Their Beer Brand Sponsors

The two Stockholm teams AIK (founded in 1891) and Hammarby (football section founded in 1915) have a long history of intense rivalry. The two teams are associated with different parts of Stockholm, and their fans show their like of their own team—and dislike of the rival team—in ways ranging from cheers of support and opposition during matches to post-game street fighting.

Swedish beer brand Åbro has been an AIK sponsor since 1993. The sponsorship is still ongoing, and Åbro has its logo prominently placed on AIK’s sweaters. Hammarby was sponsored by the Swedish beer brand Falcon between 1999 and 2009; over the years, Falcon had its logo displayed in various places of Hammarby’s uniform, including the socks and the sweater. Both beer brands officially were recognized as one of the main sponsors of their respective teams, and the AIK/Åbro and Hammarby/Falcon connections are well established among football fans in Stockholm. It is, for example, common practice that the pubs frequented by fans of one of the teams do not serve the other team’s beer.

The fact that Falcon gave up its sponsorship at the end of 2009 whereas the present study was carried out in 2010 most likely had no consequences for the results of the study. Another study, in fact, found that a long-time sponsor of an event was strongly associated with the sponsored event even two years after the sponsorship ended (Mason and Cochetel, 2006). Given the long and strong association between Hammarby and Falcon, it seems reasonable to assume that the association between the team and the sponsor still was strong a few months after the sponsorship ended.

Participants in the Experiment and Control Groups

The recruitment of AIK fans for the experiment group was aimed at finding fans who followed their team fairly closely to make sure that they were aware of the beer sponsorships of their own team AIK and the rival team Hammarby.

Participants were recruited via invitations on three AIK fan Web pages and by asking AIK supporters to forward the Web link to the questionnaire to known AIK fans in their circle of acquaintances. A potential drawback with this recruitment program was that more-active fans were likely to be more involved with their team, and several studies of football fans (e.g., Dekhil, 2010; Ko, Kim, Claussen, and Kim, 2008; Neijens, Smit, and Moorman, 2009) and fans of other types of sports (e.g., Bennet, Ferreira, Lee, and Polite, 2009) have demonstrated that involved fans are more likely to be influenced by sponsorships than non-involved fans. However, this was not regarded as a serious limitation to the study.

The questionnaire included three filter questions, asking participants

- whether AIK is their favorite Swedish football club;
- whether they drink beer; and
- their age.

Participants who indicated that AIK was not their favorite team, that they did not drink beer, or were not between the age of 18 and 35 were dropped from the analysis.

The experiment group questionnaire also had two questions asking participants how many home and away games they had attended in the previous season, and a three-item loyalty scale (Wakefield and Sloan, 1995) that included the items “I am a loyal AIK fan”; “I like to let people know that I’m an AIK fan”; and “Win or lose, I will always be an AIK fan” (responses were captured on a seven-point answer

scale). The loyalty scale has been found to be reliable in traditional psychometric terms (e.g., Nunnally and Bernstein, 1994); in the study by Wakefield and Sloan (1995; $\alpha = 0.91$); in a study by Sumino and Harada (2004; $\alpha = 0.90$); and it was reliable in the present study, too ($\alpha = 0.88$).

Consequently, the three items were averaged into a mean index (See Table 1). Responses on the game-attendance questions showed that participants regularly attended AIK games, and the mean scores on the loyalty index showed that they were loyal AIK fans (See Table 1). Game attendance was high, with an average of close to 10 home games (two-thirds of all home games) and a little more than 3 away games (a fairly high number given the time and travel costs involved in seeing away games).

The mean score on the loyalty index was close to seven on the seven-point answer scale. Thus, the experimental group was made up of active AIK fans loyal to their club. Participants were not offered any reward or incentive other than thanks for their participation.

The control group was made up of a sample from a commercial Web panel run by the Swedish market research company Sinitor (www.sinitor.se), whose panel was representative of the population of Sweden. The control group was sampled to

match the experiment group of AIK fans with respect to age and gender, and participants were filtered to make sure that they drink beer at least monthly. A control question showed that eighteen people (12 percent) in the control group had either AIK or Hammarby as their favorite team in the Swedish top league (these people were equally divided between the two teams, with nine people for each team). These individuals were excluded from further analysis. This means that the control group size was reduced from 150 to 132.

The only significant demographic difference between the experiment group and the control group was that the mean age was higher in the experiment group, but the difference was only three years (28.0 versus 24.8). To make sure that the difference in age between groups did not influence the results, age was included as a covariate in the linear mixed models (see further). However, the age variable was consistently not significant (p between 0.52 and 0.83), and the variable was not included in further analyses. In all other respects—including beer consumption (see Table 2)—the two groups were similar.

Procedure

Participants in both groups responded to the survey instrument online. For each group, there were two versions of the questionnaire: one with the questions pertaining to Åbro first and one with the questions pertaining to Falcon first.

Measures

There were three dependent variables in the study:

- purchase intention (PI_{Brand});
- brand attitude (A_{Brand}); and
- brand beliefs (B_{Brand}).

The three variables were captured with standard brand measures taken from

TABLE 2
Demographics of the
Experiment and Control Groups

	Control Group	AIK Fans
Age range	18 to 35	18 to 35
Mean age ^a	24.8	28.0
Gender:^b		
Women (%)	12.9	11.4
Men (%)	87.1	88.6
Occupation:^c		
High school (%)	3.8	5.7
University (%)	19.7	28.6
Unemployed (%)	12.9	7.6
Working (%)	56.2	59.8
Other (%)	3.8	1.9
Drinks beer:^d		
Every day (%)	1.5	1.0
2–3 times per week (%)	26.5	17.1
Weekly (%)	33.3	44.8
Monthly (%)	38.6	37.1

^aDifference between samples significant ($t = -5.07$; $p < 0.01$)

^bDifference between samples not significant ($\chi^2 = 0.12$; $p > 0.74$)

^cDifference between samples not significant ($\chi^2 = 4.79$; $p > 0.31$)

^dDifference between samples not significant ($\chi^2 = 4.47$; $p > 0.22$)

previous studies (See the Appendix; see also Bergkvist and Rossiter, 2007, for a rationale for using single-item measures for “doubly concrete” constructs).

PI_{Brand} was measured for three different usage occasions: at home, in a restaurant or bar, or for consumption together with friends at home or the home of a friend. These different usage occasions were measured separately in case social influence or the presence of others influence purchase intentions for an image product like beer.

The B_{Brand} were based on communication objectives inferred from the advertising of

TABLE 1
AIK Fan's Game Attendance
and Club Loyalty

Question	Mean (SD)
No. of home games attended previous season ^a	9.80 (5.07)
No. of away games attended previous season ^b	3.28 (3.29)
Loyalty index ^c	6.35 (1.09)

^aThe total no. of home games was 15

^bThe total no. of away games was 15

^cMeasured on a 7-point answer scale

Falcon and Åbro and interviews with beer category users.

RESULTS

The hypothesis that there is negative image transfer for a brand sponsoring a rival team was tested using linear mixed models (SPSS, 2007, pp. 48–64) with repeated measurement (to account for the fact that the participants evaluated two brands).

One model was tested for each dependent variable, making a total of nine models. The models all had the same independent variables: brand (Falcon or Åbro), group (control or experiment), and the interaction between brand and group.

Results showed a significant ($p < 0.01$) main effect of brand in all models, a significant ($p < 0.01$ or 0.05) main effect of group in five of nine models and, importantly, a significant ($p < 0.01$) interaction effect in eight of nine models.

The significant interaction was in line with the hypothesis. For the hypothesis to be supported, however, the effect of the interaction must be negative for the combination of Falcon and experiment group. In fact, the estimated fixed effects in the models (See Table 3) showed that there was a significant negative effect for the combination of Falcon and experiment group—compared to the other combinations of brand and group—for

all dependent variables except the brand belief high price.

Thus, there is support for the hypothesis that there is negative image transfer from a rival team to the brands sponsoring it.

To elucidate the differences between the experiment and control groups, Figures 1 to 3 show the interaction effect of group and beer brand on three dependent variables. (Table 4 reports mean scores on all nine dependent variables in the two groups.) In the control group, there were only small differences between the two brands; to the extent that the mean scores were significantly different, they were more positive for Falcon. The results in the experiment group were markedly different. The mean scores for Åbro were significantly higher than the mean scores for Falcon, and the differences were mostly large. In fact, for all variables, except high price, the mean score for Åbro was on the “positive” half of the answer scale, whereas the mean scores for Falcon were on the “negative” half of the answer scale (See Figures 1 to 3).

To further strengthen the results from the study, a supplementary analysis was carried out. If it could be shown that AIK fans had a negative attitude toward Hammarby (A_{Hammarby}) and if it could be shown that A_{Hammarby} covaried with the brand attitude toward Falcon

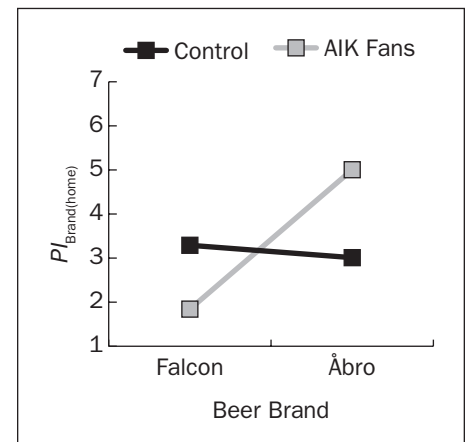


Figure 1 The Effect of Group and Beer Brand on $PI_{\text{Brand(Home)}}$

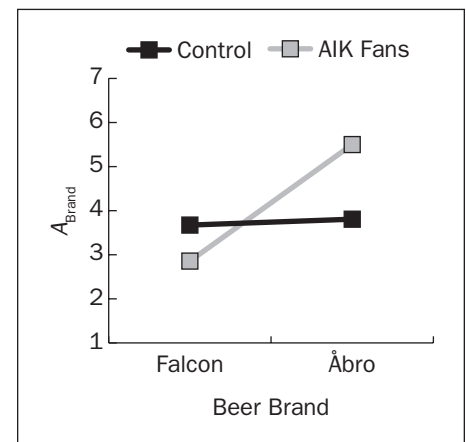


Figure 2 The Effect of Group and Beer Brand on A_{Brand}

TABLE 3

Estimates of Fixed Effects in the Linear Mixed Models

	$PI_{\text{Brand(H)}}$	$PI_{\text{Brand(R/B)}}$	$PI_{\text{Brand(F)}}$	A_{Brand}	Good Taste	High Price (Reversed)	Sporty	Manly	Relaxing
Intercept	3.03***	3.12***	3.03***	3.80***	2.59***	2.68***	1.80***	2.18***	2.28***
Brand = Falcon	0.27	0.30	0.33	-0.14	0.22*	-0.06	0.14	0.18	0.17
Group = AIK Fans	2.00***	1.63***	1.82***	1.71***	0.52***	0.24*	1.24***	0.91***	0.66***
[Brand = Falcon] × [Group = AIK Fans]	-3.40***	-2.64***	-3.32***	-2.47***	-1.36***	-0.29	-1.29***	-1.52***	-1.30***
N	237	237	237	237	237	237	237	237	237

Notes: *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$. $PI_{\text{Brand(H)}} = PI_{\text{Brand(Home)}}$; $PI_{\text{Brand(R/B)}} = PI_{\text{Brand(Restaurant/Bar)}}$; $PI_{\text{Brand(F)}} = PI_{\text{Brand(Friends)}}$

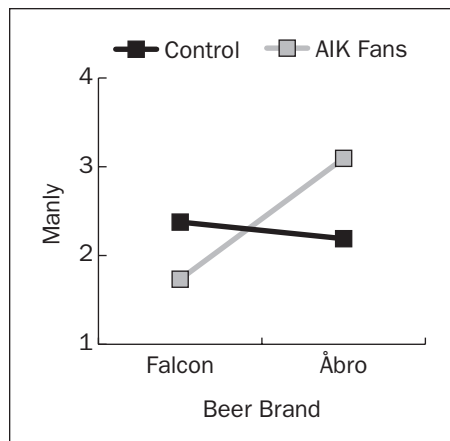


Figure 3 The Effect of Group and Beer Brand on the Brand Belief Manly.

($A_{\text{Brand}[\text{Falcon}]}$), this would support a process of image transfer from Hammarby to Falcon.

In fact, there was support for every step of this causal chain. First, the experiment group had a much more negative attitude toward Hammarby than the control group ($\bar{X}_{\text{Experiment}} = 2.22$; $\bar{X}_{\text{Control}} = 5.20$; $t = -15.66$, $p < 0.001$) (A_{Hammarby} was measured with the same type of question and seven-point answer scale that was used for A_{Brand}). Second, the correlation between A_{Hammarby} and $A_{\text{Brand}[\text{Falcon}]}$ was 0.39 ($p < 0.01$) for the experiment group, whereas it was non-significant ($p > 0.23$) for the control group.

Thus, the supplementary analysis offered further support for the hypothesis that the negative image of the rival team was transferred to its sponsors. Moreover, the results from the supplementary analysis were in line with indirect transfer (Sweldens et al., 2010), as there appeared to be an association between the object (Hammarby) and the brand (Falcon) rather than the brand generating the negative affective response independently of the object.

TABLE 4

Mean Scores (SD) on the Dependent Variables in the Two Experimental Groups

	Control Group		AIK Fans	
	Falcon	Åbro	Falcon	Åbro
$PI_{\text{Brand}[\text{Home}]}$	3.30 ^a (1.40)	3.03 ^b (1.28)	1.90 ^{a,d} (1.15)	5.04 ^{b,d} (1.77)
$PI_{\text{Brand}[\text{Restaurant/Bar}]}$	3.42 ^{a,c} (1.35)	3.12 ^{b,c} (1.20)	2.41 ^{a,d} (1.21)	4.75 ^{b,d} (1.59)
$PI_{\text{Brand}[\text{Friends}]}$	3.37 ^{a,c} (1.44)	3.02 ^{b,c} (1.26)	1.87 ^{a,d} (1.12)	4.87 ^{b,d} (1.80)
A_{Brand}	3.66 ^a (1.16)	3.80 ^b (0.97)	2.90 ^{a,d} (1.39)	5.50 ^{b,d} (1.29)
Good taste	2.81 ^{a,c} (0.93)	2.59 ^{b,c} (0.80)	1.97 ^{a,d} (0.91)	3.10 ^{b,d} (0.78)
High price (reversed)	2.61 (0.77)	2.68 ^b (0.81)	2.57 ^d (0.96)	2.90 ^{b,d} (0.89)
Sporty	1.94 (0.91)	1.80 ^b (0.79)	1.89 ^d (0.95)	3.04 ^{b,d} (1.01)
Manly	2.36 ^{a,c} (0.88)	2.18 ^{b,c} (0.89)	1.75 ^{a,d} (0.90)	3.10 ^{b,d} (0.97)
Relaxing	2.45 ^{a,c} (0.89)	2.28 ^{b,c} (0.85)	1.82 ^{a,d} (0.84)	2.94 ^{b,d} (0.94)
N	132	132	105	105

Notes:

PI_{Brand} and A_{Brand} measured on 7-point answer scales. B_{Brand} measured on 4-point answer scales

^aSignificant difference between groups (independent samples t-test, $p < 0.01$)

^bSignificant difference between groups (independent samples t-test, $p < 0.01$, except High price for which $p < 0.05$)

^cSignificant difference between brands within groups (paired samples t-test, $p < 0.01$)

^dSignificant difference between brands within groups (paired samples t-test, $p < 0.05$)

DISCUSSION

The present study demonstrated that there is a flipside to the sponsorship coin.

In certain situations, there may be negative image transfer from the sponsored object to the sponsoring brand in some groups of people. In the present case, the fans of AIK transferred their dislike of the rival team Hammarby to the Falcon beer brand. Thus, for Falcon, the sponsorship of Hammarby had negative brand effects in one group of potential buyers. The results raise a number of issues for research and for practical application.

The results in the study highlight the need for a more complex view on the fit between object and brand than has been the case in previous research. In many cases, the fit needs to be ascertained for subgroups, not for the target market as a whole. If the target market is men between 18 and 35, for instance, it may be necessary

to take their favorite football team into account when evaluating the fit between the brand and a potential sponsorship object. Or it could be that high culture has negative associations for some groups in the target market, whereas other groups have positive associations. Thus, it cannot be assumed—as appears to be an implicit assumption in much past research on sponsorship fit—that the fit between the object and the brand is the same for the entire target market.

Moreover, the type of fit studied must be chosen carefully. It is doubtful whether commonly used measures of functional or image fit would have detected the mismatch between Hammarby and Falcon in the subgroup AIK fans. Clearly, the functional fit between Hammarby and Falcon is the same as the functional fit between AIK and Åbro, which was evaluated extremely positively by the AIK fans. With respect to

image fit, it is important to make sure that the measurement is made for the specific object (football club) and not the category in general (any football club), and that the measurement picks up whether the target audience has a positive attitude toward the object, not only whether they see it as a logical fit.

The present study adds to a nascent body of research showing that marketing activities can have negative effects for the brand. A recent laboratory experiment showed that a product placement for an unknown brand in a rap video with artists with a negative image produced negative brand effects (Schemer et al., 2008). The present study adds to the literature by finding similar effects in a real-world setting, with familiar brands, and in a sponsorship context rather than for product placements.

The practical relevance of the present study is illustrated by the prevalence of beer sponsorships in the English Premier League. In the 2010–2011 season, 80 percent of the clubs were sponsored by beer brands (See Table 5). For managers, the present study points to the importance of considering the effects of sponsoring, positive and negative, in relevant subgroups of the target market. If there is a risk of negative effects in a subgroup, the sponsorship should not be selected unless it can be undertaken in such a way that it is isolated from the subgroup in question.

The study also highlights the need for including attitude toward the sponsored object when evaluating the fit between the brand and the object.

The results in the current study suggest that football sponsorships may be a double-edged sword for managers.

On the one hand, the involvement and commitment football fans have for their teams is likely to make sponsorships that create a close association between the sponsoring brand and the team more effective than most other sponsorships in

terms of creating positive brand associations and fostering brand loyalty. Under the right circumstances, football fans will bond with their team's sponsors in a similar way that they bond with their team.

On the other hand, the same close association will be a liability when it comes to fans of rival teams. Anything associated with the rival team is bad and should be avoided at all cost.

One way to address this would be for the brand to sponsor both rival teams. It is not likely, however, that fans of either team would perceive the connection between their team and the sponsor as close as if the brand exclusively sponsored their team. As a consequence, the dual sponsorship is likely to be less effective than an exclusive sponsorship.

Another possibility would be to sponsor the football league—as a whole—rather than a specific team. This could create a close association between the brand and football in general but is, again, unlikely to be as effective as creating a close association with a specific team. For example, a study of the 2006 Football World Cup suggests that sponsors of the event saw limited or no effects on their brands (Akaoui, 2007).

Taken together, this suggests that specific team sponsorships may be better for small or niche brands than for large brands or market leaders. For a small brand, it could be worth gaining a loyal following among fans of one team at the expense of losing the few customers it is likely to have among fans of the team's rivals. For a large brand, the additional sales to fans of the

TABLE 5
English Premier League Beer Brand Sponsorships

Club	Homepage	Beer sponsor
Arsenal	www.arsenal.com	–
Aston Villa	www.avfc.co.uk	Heineken
Birmingham City	www.bcfcc.com	–
Blackburn Rovers	www.rovers.co.uk	–
Blackpool	www.blackpoolfc.co.uk	–
Bolton Wanderers	www.bwfc.co.uk	Carling
Chelsea	www.chelseafc.com	Singha
Everton	www.evertonfc.com	Chang
Fulham	www.fulhamfc.com	Carling
Liverpool	www.liverpoolfc.tv	Carlsberg
Manchester City	www.mcfc.co.uk	Heineken
Manchester United	www.manutd.com	Singha
Newcastle	www.nufc.co.uk	Carling
Stoke City	www.stokecityfc.com	Carlsberg
Sunderland AFC	www.safc.com	Heineken
Tottenham Hotspur	www.tottenhamhotspur.com	Carlsberg
West Bromwich Albion	www.wba.co.uk	Carlsberg
West Ham United	www.whufc.com	Carlsberg
Wigan Athletic	www.wiganlatics.co.uk	Carling/Molson Coors
Wolverhampton Wanderers	www.wolves.co.uk	Carling

sponsored team will be smaller, and the potential loss from fans of the rival team is greater. For the large brand, it makes more sense to sponsor several teams or the football league.

- The present study was limited in some ways that open up opportunities for future research. First, the AIK fans in the experiment group were likely to be highly involved with their team. It is likely that the negative effects of sponsoring a rival team are moderated by object involvement, in the same way involvement moderates positive sponsorship effects (e.g., Bennet et al., 2009; Dekhil, 2010; Ko et al., 2008; Neijens et al., 2009).

Future research, therefore, should investigate the moderating effects of object involvement and try to determine whether there are negative sponsorship effects also for moderately involved fans or whether these arise mainly for highly involved fans.

- A second limitation is that only one product category was investigated. Beer is a low-involvement, often publicly consumed image product, and it could be a product that is particularly prone to negative sponsor effects.

Future research needs to determine whether product category moderates sponsor effects and whether negative effects are particularly likely for certain product categories. **JAR**

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APPENDIX: TABLE A1

The Dependent Variables and Their Operationalizations

Construct	Question	Answer Scale	Source
$P_{I_{Brand}}$	If you were going to buy beer for consumption AT HOME/IN A RESTAURANT/TOGETHER WITH FRIENDS IN YOUR OWN OR SOMEONE ELSE'S HOME, how likely would you be to buy ÅBRO/FALCON?	• No chance or almost no chance • Slight possibility • Some possibility • Fairly good possibility • Probable • Very probable • Certain or practically certain	Bergkvist and Rossiter (2009)
A_{Brand}	Thinking about the ÅBRO/FALCON beer, which of the following statements best describes your feeling about it?	• I think it is extremely good • I think it is quite good • I think it is slightly good • I think it is neither good nor bad • I think it is slightly bad • I think it is quite bad • I think it is extremely bad	Bergkvist and Rossiter (2009)
B_{Brand}	Below you will find a number of product properties. To what extent do you think that ÅBRO/FALCON has these properties? <i>Benefit beliefs</i> Good taste High price (reversed) Sporty Manly Relaxing	• Not at all • Somewhat • Moderately • Very	Bergkvist and Rossiter (forthcoming)

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